



WEEK ONE · MODULE FOUR

Your Client Empathy Map

The first document of your professional life

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This is not an academic exercise. It is the first version of the instrument you will keep for the rest of your career.

One page. It will take you three hours, and it should.

Submit before your mentorship session. It will be corrected in front of you, directly, and that is what you are paying for.

CHAPTER I

What you are producing, and why

The ancestor of the preference file

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- State the purpose of a client empathy map in private service.
- Understand its relationship to the preference file you will keep for decades.
- Apply the confidentiality rule that governs the exercise itself.

1.1 · The document

A single page that answers, for one principal, the questions no job description ever asks: what they are truly buying, what they fear, what irritates them, what they will never say but always expect, how you will know they are displeased before they say so, and what you would do in your first month without being asked.

1.2 · Why it matters more than it looks

This document is the ancestor of the **preference file**, the structured record that, in Week Four, you will learn to keep for a lifetime, and which is the central instrument of anticipation in this profession. Everything you will later record about a principal (their table, their allergies, their aversions, the flower she cannot bear, the dates that are difficult) begins as a discipline of attention, and this page is where that discipline is first trained.

DEFINITION

Client empathy map. A one-page synthesis of a principal's needs, fears, irritations, unspoken expectations and warning signals, written to produce action rather than understanding.

The distinction in that definition is the whole exercise. This is not a psychological portrait, and you are not being asked to be perceptive for its own sake. **Every line must imply something you would do differently tomorrow morning.** If a line implies nothing, it is an observation, and observations do not belong in this document.

1.3 · Whom you may write about

- A real principal you have served, in which case **you will change every identifying detail**: name, country, industry, the number and nature of the residences, the ages of the children. Everything.
- A public figure you have studied seriously, drawing only on what is genuinely public.

- The composite family used in this programme (see Chapter IV).

THIS INSTRUCTION IS PART OF THE EXERCISE

A map that names a real principal, or that could identify one, will be returned unread.

That is not a punishment. It is the profession. Discretion is not a chapter of this programme; it is the condition of it, and it begins with the first document you hand to me.

CHAPTER II

The specification

Seven sections, and what belongs in each

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Produce each of the seven sections to the required standard.

Rank the three levers for a specific principal, and defend the order.

Section	What belongs in it
1 · The situation	Tier of wealth. Number of residences. Number of staff. Structure above the house, is there a family office, a chief of staff? Children and their ages. The shape of their year. Facts only. No interpretation, no adjectives. Six to eight lines.
2 · What they buy	Rank time , peace and discretion for this principal, and justify the order in one sentence each. They are never equal. A candidate who says they are has not looked.
3 · What they fear	Exposure? Waste? Being managed? Their children's safety? Losing control of their own diary? Being made to feel foolish in front of people they respect? Name it precisely. Fear drives more behaviour in this world than desire does.
4 · What irritates them	The small things. The question asked twice. The unnecessary choice. The person who explains at length. The flourish. The email that could have been three words. Be specific: "bad service" is not an answer, it is a refusal to observe.
5 · What they will never say, but always expect	The heart of the document, and the section that separates the professionals from everyone else. At least five entries. At least two should be uncomfortable to write.
6 · The tells	How will you know they are displeased before they tell you? Silence? Brevity? Excessive politeness? Copying the office? In this world, going quiet is almost always the signal, and warmth withdrawing while manners increase is the loudest one there is.
7 · Your first three anticipations	Three specific actions you would take in the first month, unasked, each serving time, peace or discretion. Name which lever each one serves. They must be executable by someone else, on Monday morning, using only your page.

CHAPTER III

Standards

Weak, adequate, professional, the difference is specificity

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Distinguish a platitude from an observation.

Write section 5 to a professional standard.

Section 5 is where beginners write platitudes and professionals write the truth. Compare, and be honest about which of these you were about to write.

WEAK · WHAT A BEGINNER WRITES

“They expect excellent service.”

“They expect discretion and professionalism.”

“They expect me to be available and proactive.”

Every one is true, useless, and could be written about any wealthy person who has ever lived. It tells me you have not observed anyone, you have imagined them.

PROFESSIONAL · WHAT A PRACTITIONER WRITES

“He expects the car to be moving within ninety seconds of him standing up, and he will never say so.”

“She expects to be told about a problem only once it has a solution attached. She will forgive the delay. She will not forgive the naked problem.”

“They expect me to know which of their friends may be given the address, and never to ask them to clarify it twice.”

“He expects the chef to have been told about the dinner guests before he is asked to remember to tell me.”

“She expects that when she is short with me on a Monday, I will behave on Tuesday exactly as I did on Sunday.”

Notice what the professional lines share. Each is **falsifiable**, it could be shown to be wrong. Each is **observable**, it was learned by watching, not by imagining. And each **implies an action** you could take tomorrow. That is the standard, and there is no other.

CHAPTER IV

A complete worked example

The Marchand family, a composite, and entirely fictional

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Read a finished map at the required standard.

Use it as the shape of your own, never as its content.

Use this family if you have no principal of your own to write about. Do not copy its content, a copied map is visible in four seconds, and it will be returned.

1 · The situation

Tier: upper UHNW, approx. \$400M. Source: second-generation industrial, professionalised by the son.

Four residences: Geneva (principal), a chalet in Verbier, an apartment in Milan, a summer house in Sardinia.

Fourteen staff across the four. A single-family office in Geneva with a chief of staff, to whom I report.

Two principals, he, 54; she, 49, and three children (17, 14, 9). The eldest is at school in England.

The year: Verbier from Christmas to March; Geneva in term time; Sardinia from mid-July to late August; Milan for a week each month.

2 · What they buy, ranked

1. **Peace.** He has an operating business and a board. What he purchases at home is the absence of one more thing requiring his attention. Every unnecessary message to him is a small theft.

2. **Discretion.** A public family name in a small city. The children are recognisable at school. She fears photographs more than she fears anything else in this document.

3. **Time.** Real, but third. They are not short of hours; they are short of quiet.

3 · What they fear

That something about the children reaches the press or the school gates.

That the household becomes a subject of gossip in Geneva, where everyone knows everyone.

That they are being handled, softened, or managed by their own staff.

That an expensive mistake will be discovered by the office before it is disclosed by us.

4 · What irritates them

Being asked a question whose answer exists in a document I already hold.

A message longer than four lines when three words would do.

The flourish: the card with the flowers, the announced upgrade, the “surprise”.

Any suggestion, however implied, that something was difficult to arrange.

Staff who address him before he has addressed them, in front of guests.

5 · What they will never say, but always expect

“I expect the chalet to be at 21°C, the fire lit and the kitchen provisioned, three hours before we land, and I expect never to have discussed it with you.”

“I expect you to know which of our friends may be given the Sardinia address, and never to ask me twice.”

“I expect a problem to arrive with a solution already attached to it.”

“I expect you to have told the chef about the guests before I remember to tell you.”

“I expect that if I am short with you on Monday, you will be exactly as you were on Sunday.”

“I expect that you will never, under any circumstances, photograph my children.”

6 · The tells

She goes quiet, and becomes markedly more polite. This is the signal, and it is unmistakable once you have seen it once.

He begins to copy the chief of staff on messages that used to come to me alone. This means access is being reduced, and it is the beginning of the end unless it is addressed within a fortnight.

A request that used to come to me goes to the housekeeper instead. Same signal, quieter.

7 · My first three anticipations

Peace. Build the arrival protocol for the chalet, temperature, provisions, fire, cars, staff briefed, so that the first arrival of the season requires not one message from either principal. Test it on the empty house first.

Discretion. Establish, in writing, with the office and not with the family, the standing rule on who may be given each address, so that I never have to ask them the same question twice.

Time. Produce a one-page weekly summary of household matters, sent Friday, four lines, the same format every week, so that nothing needs to be raised with them ad hoc for the rest of the week.

CHAPTER V

The marking rubric

How I will read it, and what I am looking for

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Anticipate the five criteria against which your work is judged.

Understand which single failure results in the document being returned unread.

Criterion	What earns the mark
Specificity	Concrete, observable behaviours. Not adjectives, not aspirations. Any line that could apply to any wealthy person will be struck through.
Ranking	Time, peace and discretion are ranked for <i>this</i> principal, with a defensible reason for each position. They are never equal.
The unspoken	Section 5 contains at least five entries, and at least two are uncomfortable. The comfortable entries are, in my experience, usually the invented ones.
Action	The three anticipations could be executed on Monday morning by another person using only your page. If they could not, they are wishes.
Discretion	No real name, no identifying detail, anywhere. A breach here means the document is returned unread , regardless of the quality of the rest.
Band	Standard
Distinction	Every line implies an action. The ranking is argued, not asserted. Section 5 contains at least one line that made you hesitate before writing it.
Pass	The structure is respected and the observations are real, but several lines describe rather than imply. Honest work, and the ordinary starting point.
Rework	Platitudes in section 5; an unranked section 2; anticipations that are attitudes rather than actions; or any identifying detail. Returned, with the reason, and resubmitted before Week Two opens.

CHAPTER VI

Common failures, and submission

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Avoid the five errors that produce a rework.

Submit correctly and on time.

- **Writing the map you think I want to read.** I will know, and it wastes the only session you have this week.
- **Confusing perceptiveness with usefulness.** A beautiful psychological portrait that implies no action is a failed document, however impressive it is.
- **Adjectives in section 1.** The situation is facts. Your interpretation has six other sections in which to live.
- **Anticipations that are attitudes.** “Be attentive to her moods” is not an anticipation. “Send the Friday summary, four lines, same format, so nothing needs raising ad hoc” is.
- **Leaving in a detail you thought was harmless.** The industry, the city, the school, the number of aircraft. Any two of these identify a family. Change everything.

Submission

One page. PDF. Submitted before your mentorship session, not during it, I read it beforehand, and the session is spent on the correction rather than on the reading.

And bring me the part you are least sure about. Not the part you are proudest of. That is where the session is worth what you paid for it.

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